



Synapse School

Roadmap for Reopening

August 2020



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Synapse Philosophy

MISSION

Educating a Community of Change Makers

VISION

Build an aspirational and inspirational model of teaching SEL, innovation, and leading-edge academics

VALUES

We make and honor ambitious commitments
We give the benefit of the doubt
We are positive
We go all-in
We take care of ourselves and each other
We adapt

The Challenge and Opportunity

Many years ago a Synapse board member said to me, "I'm glad you are worried. It shows me you care." I never thought that vocalizing my concerns would actually help ease the mind of a trustee. There's always something for a Head to worry about: student safety, our school's financial health, the well-being of staff, the efficacy of our pedagogy, admissions numbers, and so on. At Synapse, we have been able to weather storms and avoid major issues not just by worrying, but by creating meaningful relationships, working together to evaluate risk, generating ideas, and planning for a crisis. This is part of what we do each and every day. Yet, we cannot eliminate risk entirely; no school can.

Our school's response to this moment is an opportunity to assert Synapse's personal and institutional values. Therefore, this Roadmap is Synapse School specific and is aligned to our unique mission and community. As we always make decisions, we lean on the power of three, equally holding the needs of students, families, and staff. That is no different in this current situation.

We choose to exercise optimism. We are anticipatory and prepared, not just for what can go wrong, but for what we can do right. This core value of ours allows us to take ownership of our options and find answers. The current challenge we face is nearly unfathomable. Juggling ever changing health and safety protocols, space restrictions, transportation challenges, family needs, child needs, staff needs, fiduciary responsibility, and educational duties, all while the clock is swiftly ticking. This will consume the entire summer for a number of us. Yet, because of who we are, because of our values and our sense of purpose, we forge ahead, and we make sure to laugh and learn, all the while holding a sense of gratitude for our roles and responsibilities.

In this Roadmap you will find Synapse's initial plans for reopening our virtual and physical campuses. Its development grew from current world-renowned scientific guidance, a clear legal framework, and the most updated and uncontroversial risk mitigation strategies to date. By necessity, this document is fluid — the scientific understanding of COVID-19 continues to evolve, complicating our efforts to understand how to best reopen safely and securely — so we must remain simultaneously committed to the plan and open to changing and adjusting it as new guidance is presented by the experts. Finally, these plans align with guidance and rules set forth by federal, state, and local officials.

What you won't see in this Roadmap are the countless hours and days the individuals and teams spent in discussion, research, and debate. You don't see the many iterations or the hundreds of communications with community members and experts. It has, and continues to be, a humbling and monumental task. My respect and admiration for the group of people who helped build this plan leaves me speechless.

We are calling on the Synapse Community to trust the deep and careful process we have undertaken as we share our Roadmap with you. None of us could have predicted the state of the world today. But here we are. We are in this together and we are excited to have you co-create this year with us.

Be well — stay safe,
Jim Eagen
Head of School

Teams

Throughout the entire process of designing our Roadmap for Reopening, a group of individuals demonstrated dedication, stamina, creativity and commitment to this herculean task.

We were also privileged to have had the opportunity to work closely with consulting experts from Stanford University and University of California, San Francisco.

The details about members of each team are listed below.

Synapse Strategic Sprint Team

Jim Eagen	Head of School
Deanna Mayer	Associate Head of School; Interim Director of Admissions
Katie Morgan	Head of Lower School
Stephanie Seto	Head of Middle School
Isha Jain	Director of Distance Learning; Middle School Math Teacher; Advisor
Liz Toomarian, PhD	Director, Brainwave Learning Center; Research Associate, Stanford University
Brian Bicknell	Director of Maker Space; STEAM Teacher; Middle School Advisor

Synapse Summer Operations Team

Jim Eagen	Head of School
Bob Bear	Chief Operating Officer
Joanne Mull	Assistant to Head of School
Mark Philips	Information Technology Associate
Thomas Werner	Facilities Associate
Hiliary Cutsinger	Business Manager
Josh Moreau	Chief Finance Officer

Synapse COVID-19 Task Force

Jim Eagen	Head of School
Amish Mehta	Founder, SQN Investors; Synapse parent
Pooja Mittal, MD	Associate Physician, Fair Oaks Health Care Center; Adjunct Clinical Associate Professor, Stanford University School of Medicine; Synapse parent
Sarah Cueva, MD	Pediatrician; Clinical Instructor, Stanford University School of Medicine; Synapse parent

Ellen Eagen	Founding Attorney, Eagen Law Firm LLC; Visiting Clinic Professor Cornell Law School; New York State Department of Education ReOpening Schools Regional Task Force
Yvonne Kunstenaar	Level II Lead Teacher, Synapse School
Scott Burke	Head of Software, Verily (Google Life Sciences); Co-Founder, Helix, former Synapse parent
Raja Kapadia	Entrepreneur; Partner, Stride; Synapse Board Member; Synapse parent
Jean-Claude Brizard	Senior Advisor and Deputy Director, Bill and Melinda Gates Foundation; Synapse parent
Bob Bear	Chief Operating Officer, Synapse School
Dave Burke, PhD	VP of Engineering, Google; Synapse parent
William Kim, PhD	Biotech IP Attorney; Fellow in Molecular Genetics and Immunology; Partner at WilmerHale

Consulting Experts

Stanford University Team:

Yvonne (Bonnie) Maldonado, MD	Senior Associate Dean, Faculty Development and Diversity, Professor of Pediatrics (Infectious Diseases) and of Health Research and Policy
C. Jason Wang, MD, PhD	Associate Professor of Pediatrics (General Pediatrics) at Lucile Salter Packard Children's Hospital and of Medicine (Pcor) and, By Courtesy, of Health Research and Policy (Health Services Research)
Benjamin A. Pinsky, MD, PhD	Associate Professor of Pathology and of Medicine (Infectious Diseases) and, By Courtesy, of Pediatrics (Infectious Diseases) at Stanford University Medical Center

University of California, San Francisco Team:

Vivek Jain, MD, MAS	Associate Professor of Medicine and Infectious Diseases, Division of HIV, Infectious Diseases & Global Medicine at San Francisco General Hospital (SFGH)
Diane Havlir, MD	Professor of Medicine, Chief of HIV/AIDS Division of UCSF School of Medicine
Kirsten Bibbins-Domingo, PhD, MD, MAS	Professor of Medicine, Chair of the Department of Epidemiology and Biostatistics, and Vice Dean for Population Health and Health Equity in the UCSF School of Medicine. Co-Founder, UCSF Center for Vulnerable Populations at Zuckerberg San Francisco General Hospital

Guiding Principles

This document offers interim guidance as we ask families to make decisions regarding their student's education for the 2020-2021 school year. This guidance is based on the current evidence and information available and will be regularly reviewed with regards to emerging evidence and the evolving nature of the pandemic. Iterations of these guidelines may be forthcoming and will be properly noticed to the community. All interim guidance will be presumed to expire in June 2021 unless otherwise specified.

Principle of Precaution

We all must recognize that there is **no zero risk**. Synapse will err on the side of caution when it comes to health and safety. Our goal is to mitigate risk and reduce harm. Children generally have less severe COVID-19 symptoms than adults, but they are not immune, can become ill with COVID-19, and they are capable of transmitting the virus among themselves and to family members or teachers. Older adults in the Synapse community - teachers, parents, grandparents, and caregivers - are at greater risk of severe COVID-19 illness.

The Best Defense: Layers

No one control strategy alone can limit the transmission of disease. Therefore, Synapse will approach the reopening of our site with a layered protection strategy. When many small interventions and strategies are applied at the same time, the scientific community believes protection is maximized. This will require our community to embrace our value of 'all-in' in order to use every control possible.

Responsibilities are to be Shared

Just as there is no single control strategy that is effective in and of itself, there is no single entity or individual solely responsible for keeping everyone safe. Synapse reopening will require continual collaboration between all constituents. That said, the final decisions regarding safe reopening and operations are at the discretion of Synapse leadership.

Limit Transmission Chains

We are **not** guaranteeing zero cases at Synapse, and we are **not** adopting a zero transmission strategy or plan. Even with the best control strategies in place, there may be cases in our community. To limit school-wide outbreaks, Synapse will take steps to limit transmission chains by keeping groups intentionally small and separate, physically distancing on campus, moving meetings for staff online, limiting numbers on campus, and employing a number of other evidence-driven strategies.

Be Flexible

The scientific community's understanding of this virus is changing quickly and daily. Synapse recognizes that the dynamic nature of knowledge during a global pandemic requires a flexible and adaptive approach, an approach we openly and proudly embrace in our school ethos and design. We're well suited to pivot as our collective understanding of this virus changes. Our value of *we adapt* must be embraced by the entire community.

Ensure Equity

Synapse recognizes that while we all may be in the same *storm at sea*, we are not all in the same *boat*. We may have some community members who are immunocompromised, some may face mental health challenges or challenges caring for members of their household. This situation may highlight the needs of students with learning differences or those needing accommodations. Some may not have adequate internet access or technology at home. We will embrace our value to *take care of each other* with compassion and equity in mind.

Action Items for Families

- ☐ Review this document to understand how the school will operate
- ☐ Complete the [Campus Choice Form](#) by July 15
- ☐ Review the [device needs](#) for your child(ren) and the **internet access recommendations** for your home.
- ☐ **Determine which mask** type(s) and style(s) works best for your child(ren) and have masks ready for your child(ren) to bring to school.
- ☐ **Practice wearing masks** in the weeks leading up to school.

CLICK HERE FOR THE
[Campus Choice Form](#)

Submit ASAP
No later than **Wednesday, July 15th**

Health Protocols and Procedures

Self-Certification and Sick Policy

Every family opting to come to campus will be asked to complete a health check/self-certification for each child each morning. To make this process as seamless as possible, we will be using a HIPAA compliant app for health self-certification. Through the app, parents will be asked to identify whether any member of their household has any symptoms of illness (e.g. cough, fever) as well as record their child's current temperature prior to coming to school each morning. More details will be shared closer to the start of school.

All members of the school community — students and staff alike — must stay at home if experiencing any symptoms of illness. Students and staff with household members who are experiencing symptoms will also be required to stay home. Distance Learning will be available for students who are not able to come to campus.

Synapse will be taking a conservative approach to all health and safety matters. We are not medical professionals and will not act as such. Instead, we will operate with an abundance of caution. With that said, here are some particulars:

- If a student or staff member has any symptoms of illness or any member of their household has symptoms, the student/staff member must quarantine for 14 days before returning to campus.
- If a student or staff member tests positive, or any individual in their household tests positive, the student or staff member must quarantine for 14 days and produce a doctor's note certifying they are fit to return to campus.
- If a student or staff member comes in contact with someone who later tests positive, the student/staff member must quarantine for 14 days and produce a doctor's note certifying they are fit to return to campus.
- If a student or staff member displays symptoms of illness during the school day, that student or staff member will be immediately separated. In the case of a student, the legal guardian will be called and the student will wait in a supervised outdoor location until pick up.
- If a student or staff member has a confirmed COVID case, the school will follow protocol for notifying families and may require certain students and staff to test or quarantine based on the existing facts.

Testing

We are developing a strategy for testing as a crucial component of our reopening. We believe that testing is important to protect our community, especially those adults willing to risk their well being to come on campus to teach and work.

When layered with a number of other health protocols, testing helps us locate those who are positive, quarantine those who came in contact with the person who tests positive, and deploy school and community-wide safety efforts and resources to help prevent a spread at our school.

Consequently, we are working with a world-class team from Stanford University to develop a testing strategy as well as an on-campus testing operation. Our initial goals as we reopen in August are two-fold:

- to make sure all students and staff have a verifiable negative test result for COVID-19 no more than 72 hours before arrival on campus
- to provide regular testing to all students and staff on our campus using lower nasal swabs to start

Please know, because testing methods, efficacy and supplies are evolving daily, our plans for testing are likely to change. For example, if deep nasal swabs are the only option for Synapse testing, we will not test regularly. If easier methods of testing, with quicker turnaround times, become available, we may test more often.

What won't change is our belief that testing for COVID-19 is a vital part of any safe reopen plan and will become standard practice over the coming months. As others look to explore this critical step in improving safety for staff and students, we hope to be a leader in how to successfully incorporate an effective testing protocol and program in schools.

Participation in the testing protocol will be required if you choose to send your child to campus. Closer to the start of school, before families make their final decision on whether to allow their children to learn on campus, we will provide you with the specific protocol testing protocol.

Physical Spaces

Current evidence indicates that COVID-19 transmission is less prevalent outdoors and in well-ventilated areas. To this end, we are constructing multiple learning spaces that are completely outside, as well as modifying our larger, more open indoor spaces to maximize air volume and circulation. For example, Buildings 2, 3 and 4 have undergone construction to remove several walls and barriers to open up spaces, and to improve air flow and our ability to practice physical distancing.

Outdoor Classrooms with shade structures

- Two - 20' x 20' tents on the Lower School playground
- Two - 16' x 32' tents on the Middle School playground
- One - 16' x 32' tent over existing Garden benches
- One - 20' x 45' tent over new expanded garden with new turf in Building 4 parking lot
- One - 16' x 25' tent outside office/classroom in Building 4 lot

Example of outside classrooms for both shade and rain protections:



Reference photo from February, 2020

Air Quality and Filtration

We have also made a number of facilities upgrades to improve air quality/filtering and increase air flow indoors, including:

- Increased fresh air percentage in HVAC units from 0 to 30%
- Upgraded to Merv 13/HEPA filters in all HVAC units
- Installed roll-up security grill doors to large roll-up doors in Building 1, allowing us to safely keep them open during the day

Touchless Technology

The entrance to the Building 3 lobby will be automated, eliminating the need to touch the door handle.

We are in the process of installing touchless (motion-sensing) faucets, soap dispensers, and towel dispensers in all bathrooms.

Physical Distancing Measures

As soon as students arrive on campus, they will begin practicing physical distancing. Classroom spaces have been redesigned such that students will see visual reminders that physical distancing is expected. Our first days together will be, in large part, about learning these new norms.



Photo of new color-blocked carpet installed in the Building 2, Playspace

Personal Protective Equipment (PPE)

Teachers and students will be required to wear masks while at school. Occasional “mask breaks” will be taken during snack time and/or at the discretion of the teacher.

We strongly encourage all families to practice wearing masks in the weeks leading up to school. There are many mask types and styles, and it is important that you determine which works best for your child. We encourage students to bring their own mask, but disposable masks will also be available at school.

All staff will undergo training on items such as proper use of PPE and cleaning protocols.

Cleaning and Disinfection

Hygiene

Hand washing will occur at regular intervals throughout the day, and hand sanitizer will be located throughout all learning spaces.

Cleaning and Sanitizing

Physical learning spaces, including table tops and other high-touch surfaces, will be disinfected regularly throughout the course of the day, including between morning and afternoon on-campus sessions. Our contracted cleaning crew will do a thorough cleaning every night with disinfectants recommended by the Center for Disease Control and Prevention.

Classroom Supplies

Supply-sharing will be minimized. Closer to the beginning of school, families will be provided with a list of basic school supplies that they should have available for their student.

Food

Synapse will not provide food. Students should bring their own snacks. Food brought by students/staff will not be shared and physical distancing will be practiced while students eat.

Cohorts

For on-campus cohorts, we are using a *stable cohort* structure, which involves reducing group sizes by at least half, and requiring physical distancing with face coverings (e.g. masks).

The purpose of a stable cohort is to minimize mixing of its group members with others, while still allowing for necessary and practical flexibility for the educational program. Stable cohorts are intended to create as consistent an environment as is practicable by reducing numbers of students and the movement of students across campus. With stable cohorts, we are still able to perform contact tracing, should a case of COVID-19 arise. (For more information on stable cohorts see the San Mateo County Office of Education's *Pandemic Recovery Framework for Schools*)

When on campus, the number of students in a cohort will be dependent on space available. For example, cohorts using an outdoor classroom (under a playground tent) may only have space for 8 students, while a larger open indoor space may accommodate 10-12 students.

Large Group Gatherings

All large in-person gatherings will either be postponed (athletics, field trips). Virtual platforms will be used as an alternative to in-person gatherings when meaningful. These include, but are not limited to: All School Assemblies, Back to School Night, Portfolio Days, Town Halls, Staff meetings, and SynC meetings.

Program Overview

Synapse is offering two options as we open school on August 6th. The **Hybrid** option and the **100% Distance Learning** option. The hybrid option consists of half days on campus (mornings for Lower School, afternoons for Middle School) and half days online. The 100% Distance Learning option is online for both morning and afternoons.

We ask families to think about these options and complete the Campus Choice Form to indicate your current leaning as soon as possible, but no later than Wednesday, July 15.

Hybrid Option

The Hybrid option is a combination of on-campus as well as Distance Learning.

On-Campus Learning in the Hybrid Option

We chose half days on campus because health and safety protocols require that we try to reduce by half the number of staff and students on campus at any one time. After considering many variables, we ultimately settled on a schedule that allows both lower and middle school students to come to campus every day for several hours.

Some of the variables we considered are:

- Consistency of daily routines
- Half days on campus results in fewer transitions during which students will need to move from one place to another (thus, reducing exposure)
- Fewer consecutive hours equals reduced exposure (likelihood of viral transmission increases with exposure time)
- In-person interactions with peers and teachers every day
- Opportunity to work with different peers (on-campus and online) every day
- Reduced time in potentially extreme weather conditions (i.e. heat and sun exposure)

When on campus, students will move with the same group of students. These groups will be referred to as cohorts. See [Cohorts and Placement](#) below for more information.

For more details about [Health and Safety Procedures](#) please see that section above.

Distance Learning in the Hybrid Option

Incorporating Distance Learning into the Hybrid option means increased opportunities for students to have one-on-one time with teachers, to work in small groups, as well as to interact with and learn from more teachers than they can from their on-campus stable cohorts.

Students who have opted for 100% Distance Learning will be incorporated into the on-campus experience whenever possible (see next section). In addition, in order to minimize exposure, some on-campus classes will be delivered by a teacher via video conferencing.

Transition time is built into the middle of the day to allow for transportation to and from campus in order to begin the second part of the school day. Full days will begin during the second week of school.

More details about the [schedule](#) can be found below.

100% Distance Learning Option

In this option, the Synapse program will be delivered 100% online. Our goal is to enable students who choose this option to have a well-rounded learning experience. We are currently exploring various technologies to assist with integrating remote students into on-campus classrooms. Depending on the number of students selecting the 100% Distance Learning option and the technologies available, we may integrate remote students into on-campus classrooms. There may also be times when remote students will have experiences (e.g. small group discussions, group work, PE) that are developed specifically for the digital environment, while on-campus students are experiencing something similar but in person.

While Distance Learning cannot replicate in-person opportunities for interaction, the learning goals for remote students will be the same as for the students who choose hybrid learning.

Cohort Structure & Placement

For an explanation of the stable cohort structure, please see the [Cohorts](#) subsection of [Health Protocols and Procedures](#).

Lower School students will be with one main teacher for their campus experience and may see or interact with specialists either in person or through Zoom, depending on scheduling availability. Placement in campus cohorts is dependent on the number of students opting to come to campus and staffing availability. For the Lower School, this may not follow the Lead/Associate team structure. In the afternoons, Lower School students will be in Lead/Associate *classes*. This means that Lower School students will have two cohorts: a morning cohort and an afternoon cohort. In some circumstances, that may mean a Lower School student has three teachers, instead of just two! Lead/Associate classes will be mixed age groups. On-campus cohorts may be either grade-specific or mixed age groups, depending on the number of students coming to campus.

Middle School students will be with one teacher and their cohort for their campus experience. Placement in cohort groups is dependent on the number of students opting to come to campus and staffing availability. While students are in distance learning, they will be in two additional cohorts: advisory and one other learning cohort. Advisories will be grade-specific, and the on-campus and distance learning cohorts may be either grade-specific or mixed grade groups, depending on the number of students coming to campus. Middle School students will be interacting with all of their teachers, whether in-person or through Distance Learning.

For every student, we try to consider social and friendship dynamics, as well as relationships between students, teachers, and guardians. Placement decisions will be made closer to the start of school, giving us time to account for responses to the [Campus Choice form](#) and any other changing conditions. Fortunately, we are in the enviable position of having many teachers in the Lower School and Middle School, and we are working to host as many students on campus as possible given the health and safety protocols.

Ultimately, it is important to remember that we are all in an unprecedented situation, working to make the best decisions that we can for your children. Due to safety concerns, and because we put a lot of careful thought into our placements, we cannot consider cohort/teacher/advisor placement change requests.

Schedule: August 6 - 14, 2020

The first five days of school will be half days for all students. Starting August 13th, there will be full days for all students.

For Families Choosing the Hybrid Option

Different Levels will begin coming to campus on different days. Prior to your student starting their on-campus experience, they will be in Distance Learning. Please see the table below.

Note: 100% Distance Learning runs concurrently with the Hybrid schedule.		THURSDAY August 6 <i>HALF DAY</i>		FRIDAY August 7 <i>HALF DAY</i>	
		Level I	First Day on Campus!	On Campus	
		Level II	Distance Learning	First Day on Campus!	
		Level III	Distance Learning	Distance Learning	
		Middle School	Distance Learning	Distance Learning	

MONDAY August 10 <i>HALF DAY</i>		TUESDAY August 11 <i>HALF DAY</i>		WEDNESDAY August 12 <i>HALF DAY</i>		THURSDAY August 13 <i>FULL DAY</i>		FRIDAY August 14 <i>FULL DAY</i>	
Level I	On Campus	All LS Levels On Campus		All LS Levels On Campus		AM: On Campus PM: Distance Learning		AM: On Campus PM: Distance Learning	
Level II	On Campus								
Level III	First Day on Campus!								
Middle School	Distance Learning	Distance Learning		Distance Learning		AM: Distance Learning PM: First Day on Campus!		AM: Distance Learning PM: On Campus	

On Campus Drop-Off and Dismissal

8:10 - 8:30am Lower School Campus Drop-Off

11:30 - 11:50am Lower School Dismissal and Pick-Up

1:00 - 1:15pm Middle School Campus Drop-Off

4:00 - 4:15pm Middle School Dismissal and Pick-Up

Specific protocols around drop-off and pick-up procedures will be shared closer to the start of school.

Daily Schedules: Sample Overviews

Sample Hybrid Schedules

LOWER SCHOOL

8:10 - 8:30	<i>Morning Drop Off</i>
Morning: On Campus	<i>Morning Movement/ PE Morning Meeting HEARTS Investigations</i>
8:30 School Begins	<i>Specialist Lessons Hygiene, Snack, & Movement Breaks</i>
11:30 Dismissal	
11:45 - 1:15	<i>Travel Home Lunch at Home Exercise</i>
Afternoon: Distance Learning	<i>Afternoon Meeting Specialist/ Small Group Lessons</i>
1:15 School Begins	<i>1-1 Meetings / Independent Learning</i>
3:30 Dismissal	<i>Closing Meeting</i>

MIDDLE SCHOOL

8:10 - 8:45	<i>Get ready for school!</i>
Morning: Distance Learning	<i>Morning PE Advisory</i>
8:45 School Begins	<i>Classes Snack & Movement Breaks</i>
11:45 Dismissal	
11:45 - 1:15	<i>Lunch at Home Travel to Campus</i>
Afternoon: Distance Learning	<i>Classes Group Work Time Social Time</i>
1:15 School Begins	<i>Physical Breaks Hygiene, Snack, & Movement Breaks</i>
4:00 Dismissal	

Sample 100% Distance Learning Schedules*

LOWER SCHOOL

8:10 - 8:30	<i>Get ready for school!</i>
Morning: Distance Learning	<i>Morning Movement/ PE (Zoom into) Morning Meeting (Zoom into) Campus HEARTS Investigations</i>
8:30 School Begins	<i>Snack / Play (Zoom into) Campus Specialist Time</i>
11:30 Dismissal	
11:45 - 1:15	<i>Lunch at Home</i>
Afternoon: Distance Learning	<i>Afternoon Meeting Specialist/ Small Group Lessons</i>
1:15 School Begins	<i>1-1 Meetings / Independent Learning</i>
3:30 Dismissal	<i>Closing Meeting</i>

MIDDLE SCHOOL

8:10 - 8:45	<i>Get ready for school!</i>
Morning: Distance Learning	<i>Morning PE Advisory Classes</i>
8:45 School Begins	<i>Snack & Movement Breaks</i>
11:45 Dismissal	
11:45 - 1:15	<i>Lunch at Home</i>
Afternoon: Distance Learning	<i>(Zoom into) Classes (Zoom into) Group Work Time Social Time</i>
1:15 School Begins	<i>Snack & Movement Breaks</i>
4:00 Dismissal	

* Depending on the number of students in DL, we will either integrate students into campus sessions via video conferencing or host DL classes

In the event that we have to close campus, the program will be delivered entirely online.

Sample Campus Closure Distance Learning Schedules*

LOWER SCHOOL

8:10 - 8:45	<i>Get ready for school!</i>
Morning: Distance Learning	<i>Morning Meeting/ PE HEARTS Investigations Specialist Time</i>
8:45 School Begins	
12:00 - 1:00	<i>Lunch Break Quiet Time/ Choice Time</i>
Afternoon: Distance Learning	<i>Small Group Work 1-1 Meetings with Teachers Independent Work Time</i>
3:00 Dismissal	<i>Closing Meeting</i>

MIDDLE SCHOOL

8:10 - 8:45	<i>Get ready for school!</i>
Morning: Distance Learning	<i>Morning PE Advisory Classes</i>
8:45 School Begins	<i>Snack & Movement Breaks</i>
12:00 - 1:00	<i>Lunch Break</i>
Afternoon: Distance Learning	<i>Classes PE</i>
3:30 Dismissal	<i>Snack & Movement Breaks</i>

* Depending on developmental ages and stages, level/grade schedules may vary in their dismissal times.

Other Program Elements

Nature Days

Pending the opening and availability for groups at parks, we hope to have Nature Day as part of the program for both Lower and Middle School students. This will provide opportunities to be outside and engage with the natural world, balancing out the screen time that distance learning demands. Led by Riekes staff, students will be in their stable campus cohorts and accompanied by Synapse teachers.

Riekes Center Programming for Middle School

While we will still be partnering with the Riekes Center for both Nature Days and our 7/8 Performing Arts ensembles, as of now, students will not be traveling to the Riekes Center.

PE, SportsHouse, and Middle School Team Sports

As of now, students will not be traveling to SportsHouse for PE.

Physical activity will remain part of the schedule and program. PE that takes place on campus will require students to maintain physical distancing, and may include activities like games, aerobic activities, yoga, etc. PE through distance learning will be both synchronous and asynchronous.

The Small Schools Intermediate League (SSIL), with whom we organize our Middle School team sports, will be basing their game and meets schedule on local authority recommendations.

Supervised Distance Learning & After Care

Our ability to host students and siblings on campus for Supervised Distance Learning (afternoons for Lower School, and mornings for Middle School) — as well as to host an After Care, once programming is complete — is dependent on the total number of students on campus, space available, and staffing considerations. If we are able to safely offer Supervised DL and After Care, it will begin on Thursday, August 13, 2020.

For Supervised DL, students will work independently with their devices and headphones, with a cohort of other students of various ages. For After Care, students will continue to be physically distant, and participate in organized activities as well as independent activities. Students should bring their own snacks. While the specifics (e.g. size of group, location of learning space) is dependent on how many guardians express a need for this kind of care, as well as the total number of students on campus, we will be following the same layered protection protocols as on-campus learning (e.g. physical distancing, masks).

In your [Campus Choice form](#), you will be given the opportunity to indicate for each child whether you would regularly utilize Supervised DL and/or After Care. Specific times will be confirmed closer to opening.

Shuttle Services

Synapse contracts with KidzJet to provide a shuttle service. For families who are interested in the shuttle program, KidzJet will be communicating additional information related to their safety precautions.

Technology, Tools, and Communication

Technology, tools, and communication are crucial to the success of our program.

Tool	Audience	Description
Devices & Internet Access	Staff, Guardians, Students	Each student should have access to a device with a stable internet connection in order to participate in Distance Learning at Synapse. If this is a challenge, please contact helpdesk@synapseschool.org .
	Lower School Students	Synapse will provide: - iPads for K-4, likely to be available mid-September* - iPad case/cover - Stylus and keyboard for grades 3-4 - For LIII students, we may have limited chromebooks available for use until iPads are available. Please contact Katie & helpdesk@synapseschool.org to inquire. Families should provide: - Headphones when on campus - Computer or iPad for distance learning at home until school provided iPads arrive
	Middle School Students	- Headphones when on campus Laptops: Students in 5th grade through 8th grade are required to have a laptop for school purposes. The recommendations and requirements for the laptop are as follows: Recommendations for Middle School Student Computers: - MacBook (Air or Pro) or Windows PC Laptop - i5 processor (or better - i7 processor) 4GB RAM (or better - 8GB) 160GB internal hard drive (or better - 256GB solid state drive) Requirements for Middle School Student Computers: - No Chromebooks - students are unable to download necessary programs for class on Chromebooks - Students must have administrator accounts or parents must email Sophie Scafani, Assistant to the Division Heads, with student's computer admin information (username + password) at sophie.scafani@synapseschool.org
Email	Staff, Students, Guardians	Email is a crucial means of communication for faculty/staff, students, leadership, and families. During the upcoming year, Synapse will still send the weekly newsletter and class notes. Additionally, teachers will rely on email for communication with students and families. During the school

		year, please allow 48 hours for staff to respond to your email. Note: Each Synapse student has their own Synapse email address. Students who have not used their Synapse email address before will receive more details in August regarding access/activation.
Text-Em-All	Staff, Guardians	Synapse utilizes this emergency text message system in the event that the entire community needs to be contacted urgently. A test text will be sent 1-3 times per year. You will be notified by email at the time the system is tested.
Zoom	Staff, Students, Guardians	Zoom is the primary means of video conferencing for distance classes, as well as the primary mode for parent-teacher conferencing and other large group meetings. Phone calls are also a possibility for conferencing and meeting with staff.
Google Drive	Staff, Students, Guardians	Parent Access Folders: This is where you'll find your student's Personal Education Plan (PEP). This folder is typically shared with the guardian email addresses we have on file, and the student's email address. Google Suite: Through their Gmail accounts, students will have access to Google Docs, Google Sheets, Google Forms, etc.
Google Calendar	Staff, Students, Guardians	The Synapse Community Calendar is a calendar for Synapse parents/guardians, SynC, faculty and staff • The link to this calendar is shared at the start of each year. • People with the link may subscribe to this calendar if they want events to automatically show up on their personal calendars. • This calendar includes private school community events, all SynC events, details on events, including where & when. Specific level or class calendars may be shared by teachers through email or the weekly class notes.
Learning Management Systems	Staff, Students, Guardians	Seesaw*: Grades K-2 will use Seesaw to manage assignments, course materials, and provide feedback. Google Classroom*: Grades 3-8 will use Google Classroom to manage classroom communications, assignments, and course materials. Feedback may be given in Google Classroom, or directly on student work. Teachers will share account information in August. We encourage you to explore these tools on your own, too, before account information is available. *If we find that it helps when beginning the school year, Lower School teachers and/or teams may also maintain a Google Sheet with daily lesson plans and links to resources, materials needed, and a Zoom link.
Health Certification App	Guardians	Families will use an app to self-certify that everyone in the household is symptom-free before coming to campus each morning. Guardians will receive more information closer to school start.

Newsletter	Staff, Guardians, Students	Weekly newsletters will be sent on Fridays. Newsletters include announcements, dates, event details, and other important information for the community.
Class Notes	Staff, Guardians	Once the school year begins, teachers send weekly class notes on Fridays. Class notes include summaries of the week, as well as level- or grade-specific information and events.
School Website	Staff, Guardians, General Public	The School Updates page on www.synapseschool.org is kept up-to-date with the latest news for our community.
My Synapse (Parent Portal)	Current Families	Here you will find the Distance Learning page , with links to the resources you will need for your family to follow Synapse's Distance Learning plan. This page will be updated closer to the start of school.

Campus Choice

This [Campus Choice Form](#) is our effort to gather your **current leaning** regarding sending your child to campus. If you choose to send your child to campus you will be required to comply with the following:

- Daily use of the health screening app to self-certify
- Signing a waiver of liability, acknowledging the inherent risks of coming to campus and assuming those risks.
- Participation in the testing protocol

Families will be asked to make their final decision closer to reopening.

Please complete the [Campus Choice Form](#) by Wednesday, July 15, 2020. Having these early indicators will help us better prepare for the reopening of school.

Switching from 100% Distance Learning to Hybrid

Due to the evolving nature of the pandemic, we understand that there are factors beyond a family's control that might impact the decision to come to campus.

We want to be able to accommodate the changing circumstances of our families. Parents have the ability to reassess the risks and relevant facts and switch from Hybrid to 100% Distance Learning.

If you wish to switch your student from 100% Distance to Hybrid, there are a number of logistics that take time and make the switch challenging. Accommodating choices requires the school to be shifting roles and responsibilities of staff; and, thus, we ask parents to be mindful and patient while we make those changes.

Questions?

Come to the Drop-in hours with the Strategic Sprint Team **on Tuesday 7/14 or Wednesday 7/15** from 10:00am to 11:00am. Zoom link: <https://zoom.us/j/93899188900>

CLICK HERE FOR THE
Campus Choice Form

Submit ASAP
No later than **Wednesday, July 15th**

Calendar for 2020 - 2021

A PDF version of the calendar is [attached here](#) for your reference. Due to the unpredictable nature of the pandemic, we reserve the right to modify the calendar as the year progresses.

Friendly reminder to add the [Synapse Community Calendar](#) to your online calendar.